

Critique of a Records Management Policy: Rowan University

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Policy Scope and Transparency

Rowan University is a mid to large size public university in New Jersey. The policy statement lists the main objectives of the records management policy as the efficient management of records to support the function of the university and comply with legal regulations (Rowan University, 2025). The policy seems to stipulate that the records management policy exists to help with the overall management of the institution. However, both that explanation and the policy itself feels a bit vague for explaining the specific needs that come with managing the records of a mid to large size university with multiple colleges that is listed as an R2 research institution. The policy feels like it could apply to any type of organization, and was not specifically written for a university as there is a lack of explicit mention of stakeholders like the student body, faculty, and alumni of the institution. There is also no mention of the importance of a records management policy to aid the vast different variety of record types that a university manages like academic records as opposed to financial, or administrative. Essentially the records management policy fails to address the specific needs of a university that separate it from other types of organizations. Using ARMA's Information Governance Maturity Model, while the policy itself is transparent in the fact that it is documented and available, it appears that the Rowan University records management policy falls within Level 2 because it has begun to document its records management processes but only in a very vague way that doesn't provide ample insight into business processes and activities beyond the surface level (ARMA, n.d.). There is also no mention transparency as a principle that guides their policy.

Defining a Record

Rowan University defines a record as "any and all data or information in a fixed form and in any format that is created or received in the course of institutional activity and retained as evidence of that activity for future reference" (Rowan, 2025, sec. 4). Examples are provided for the types of material that are covered under this definition including things like photographs, sound and moving images, electronic and machine-readable data, and other materials regardless of their physical form. The definition of a record then gets expanded to cover several categories of records recognized as important as a part of the

institution's daily operation including vital records, electronic records, archival records, active records, inactive records, and expired records.

As Yeo states there are multiple definitions of a record which are dictated by both industry differences and their relationship to concepts like information and evidence (2007). Rowan's definition of a record more closely aligns with the International Standard Organization's (ISO) definition of a record which is defined as "information created, received and maintained as evidence and as an asset by an organization or person in pursuance of legal obligations or the transaction of business" (ISO, 2001, pp. 3). Both the ISO and Rowan's definition focus on the evidentiary value of record to prove organization activity. The Rowan definition also borrows from the ARMA definition by purposefully stating that records are defined regardless of their characteristics or format (Franks, 2018). The definition of a record that Rowan University proved is usable as it captures the main functionalities that have been stipulated by organizations like ISO and ARMA, however as we later see throughout the exploration of the policy, the university's policy doesn't quite explore the evidentiary aspects of record throughout its records management programs.

Accountability

The function and responsibilities for the records management program were found lacking in the record management policy. The Rowan University records management policy places the responsibility of the records management program in the hands of individual local units which are made up of either departments, divisions or areas within the university. These units are responsible for identifying a records management liaison who is in charge of ensuring proper management of records. They must ensure that their unit is properly storing records, decide where to store records from a selection of authorized locations, oversee proper maintenance of record during the retention period, ensure accessibility and security, and enforce the proper disposal of records in a way that is consistent with policies. If assistance is needed the local units can reach out to the Records Management Program (Rowan University, 2025).

A separate section is provided to cover the responsibility of the Records Management Office who exists to provide the resources and information needed to manage all functions of a records management program. They provide services like developing retention schedules, assisting with the inventory of active

records and analyzing a department's active record-keeping systems, retrieving records upon request, arranging the proper disposal of records, assisting with developing preparations for records in the case of disaster, and providing consultations to departments needing guidance of records management. There was also brief mention of the President, Central Administrator, and the Dean of each school appointing a Records Liaison who assists the University's Custodian of Records in executing the Records Management policy and oversees the maintenance of the policy. General training regarding record management policy and procedures are provided through the Director of Ethics program (Rowan University, 2025)

After the application of the ARMA Information Governance Maturity Model's principle of accountability, Rowan University's policy would fall within the Level 3 range, where the essentials of identifying who is responsible for the records management program are provided, but nothing more.

While we are made aware of the roles of a record manager, the assistance that the Records Management Office provides, and the involvement of higher management in developing the policies and procedures of a records management program the Rowan University records management policy fails to identify the presence of a committee that is responsible for advising and approving changes to records management policies and record retention schedules (ARMA, n.d.). Universities produce a lot of born digital records, so it is important to cast a wide net for proper representation of what it is needed to develop records management programs and policies when putting a committee together. "Policy teams must include representatives from the appropriate functional areas, such as records management, information technology, business units, compliance, human resources, sales and marketing, and communications and public relations" (Franks, 2018, pp. 33-34). A representative from the archives should also be present from the inception of the committee to ensure that records are being captured with the information that will be needed if they are deemed as necessary to preserve for their historical value.

By building out the Rowan University's portion of the policy that covers accountability, members of the university will have a more well-rounded understanding of who is responsible for information governance throughout the entirety of a records management program, from the top management level of developing policies, to training of employees, and the process of the maintenance of a record itself.

Compliance

Rowan University's Records Management Policy does an adequate job identifying the relevant laws and regulations that direct record management both at the state and federal level. The policy clearly states their adherence to N.J.S.A. Title 47 which stipulates the policies related to the handling of public records (State of New Jersey Government Records Council, 2023), the Department of State, Division of Archives and Records Management (DARM), and N.J.A.C. 15:3 et seq. which is New Jersey's state policy for records retention (Department of State, 2025). The policy also provides detail of specific laws and regulations upheld by type of record. Information is provided for the regulations upheld for records with protected health information according to New Jersey code and also provides note of when federal regulations like HIPAA and FERPA supersede state regulations (Rowan University, 2025).

The policy rates as a Level 3 in the ARMA Information Governance Maturity Model. Compliance is of high value and has been identified in the university's policy. There is even mention of the possibility of audit and the need to retrieve records in that instance. However, there is no mention of the processes used to measure compliance or of the risk that could ensue if that information is not captured. There is also not much information about audits beyond the fact that they could happen meaning that no clearly defined regular audit procedures are identified to ensure that departments are compliant. A lot of thought is put into stating that records management procedures should comply with policies and regulations, but there is no mention of how the university ensures that the policies in place are in fact followed, or what should happen if they are not. Palmer discusses the importance of ensuring compliance with record management standards, the need to implement regular audits, and proper training to protect against the risk of corruption that noncompliance can bring (Palmer, 2000).

Record Format Requirements

While the records management policy defines electronic records and gives examples of what they might encompass, it doesn't do a good job distinguishing how their management differs from physical records. "Electronic records are challenging to manage, especially as electronic information is being created in volumes that pose significant technical challenges to the ability to organize and make it accessible" (Melvin, 2010, pp. 1). Electronic records come in much more complex formats and can be

static or dynamic (Franks, 2018) which requires different measures for capture, organization and maintenance than purely physical documents would. The policy often applies a basic approach of stating that all records, even the electronic ones, must oblige by the policies stipulated and very rarely acknowledges that the management of electronic records might require separate processes. There is a brief mention of electronic records needing to be created on university standard software and whatever locations are hosting these electronic files also have to adhere to standards and procedures (Rowan University, 2025). Brief mention to the difference between electronic and physical records is made to discuss how electronic records can't just be deleted to be properly disposed of and must be wiped clean to meet proper disposition standards.

Because of the lack of differentiation between electronic records and physical records, the Rowan University policy doesn't provide any information on things that relate specifically to the electronic records management process like the use of autoclassification to help with e-discovery. There is also no mention of the use and importance of metadata at the point of capture of electronic records to help with e-discovery as well (Franks, 2018).

Functions of a Records Management Program

The policy briefly mentions the functions of a records management program, but it is a very surface level exploration of the functions and doesn't provide guidance or explanation on what happens at each stage of the records management program. No attention is paid to the creation/capture stage of the program. All explanation of the records management program seems to begin with active files that must be maintained. But, the creation and capture stage of a records program are vital to the program as a whole because of what gets captured at that stage. The stage of capture of a record ties back directly to what makes a record a record because this is where we begin the evidentiary process. As Frank states, the capture process is where we capture the characteristics needed to prove authenticity, reliability, integrity, and usability. (Franks, 2018). Organizations should create guidelines and policies to ensure that the right metadata is being collected that will follow the record throughout its lifecycle and prove authenticity. Without proper guidance for exactly what should be captured, records run the risk of being useless regarding evidentiary value and put the organization as a whole at risk.

Storage is a vague function in the policy as well. I'm inclined to think that this is intentionally so because the records management policy stipulates that records management liaisons of each local unit decide where records are stored as long as that location has been authorized by Records Management Program. No mention is given towards the systems required to store records. Is the university still keeping physical copies of certain records? If so, a storage process must be stipulated for how to move records to these locations, and well on information on how records should be retrieved from storage. The same goes for electronic records management systems. Conversation should be had about whether digital records should be stored internally or if they would fare better on the cloud. And if they are stored on the cloud, attention needs to be paid to making sure that the cloud system meets regulation (Barnes, 2010). There is also vagueness regarding the function of storage due to the organization's failure to state what should be happening with records after they have been captured and exist in storage. According to the policy, they just seem to exist until they aren't needed anymore. What's missing within the policy is guidance on how these records should be classified and filed while they are still active and being retained (Franks, 2018). What filing systems and classification systems are used to make records searchable and retrievable during the storage phase of the records management program? The lack of guidance regarding capture and storage put the Rowan University policy within the category of Level 1 regarding record integrity. No mention is given towards proving authenticity. Regarding the principle of availability, the policy scores a level 1 on the ARMA Maturity Model (ARMA, n.d.). No guidance is given towards making records available for retrieval or discovery.

Regarding retention, the policy states that records have to be properly maintained according to regulation while they are active and inactive according to the retention schedule. Retention schedules can also be revised periodically to change retention periods, or to address record that are no longer needed. While we don't get to see exactly which methods, for example the big bucket method, are used to consolidate record types to create a retention schedule, the policy explicitly states that the university provides a list of official records and their prescribed retention periods by department. The information regarding the retention schedule also lets employees know that the retention schedule itself will provide information on how the document must be disposed (Rowan University, 2025). The Rowan University policy towards retention seems to be adequate and falls at a Level 3 on the ARMA Maturity Model as it

stipulates a policy and gives university employees information on what the retention schedule contains and how it should be used (ARMA, n.d.). They also point employees towards a specific office if they require assistance with their retention schedule.

It feels like the bulk of attention is given to the process of disposition during the records management program. Attention is given to provide the definition of a retention schedule and what constitutes disposing of records properly for both physical and electronic records. A process is laid out for how to dispose of a record according to DARM, which includes the process of needing to get proper written authorization from DARM before the process can move forward. Instructions are also given for who's signatures need to be acquired. The policy seems to rate at a Level 4 regarding disposition when looking at the ARMA Maturity Model (ARMA, n.d.).

Protection

The policy provides a basic statement on the need to protect information using secure methods and mentions following HIPAA, FERPA, and public information policies but doesn't go beyond that. It is all very surface level and doesn't talk about what security and privacy entail when it comes to records management. The Rowan University policy fails to include information on security and the need to establish access controls to navigate who has access to which records. There is no clear policy guidance on protecting information of various media types and no specific guidance is given to employees on how to address it. No mention is given towards the need to implement measures to control access both physically and digitally to protect information throughout all stages of the records management lifecycle to prove authenticity and protect against risk (Franks, 2018). For this reason, the policy scores as a level 2 because it stipulates that privacy and security is needed but doesn't provide any sort of guidance towards how that is achieved (ARMA, n.d.).

Conclusion

Rowan University's records management policy was found to be lacking and regularly fell below the Level 3 essential status according to the ARMA Maturity Model. While it seems to contain aspects of all the principles needed to create a records management policy it lacked depth. More thought should be given towards moving towards developing a policy that meets proactive or transformational levels.

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